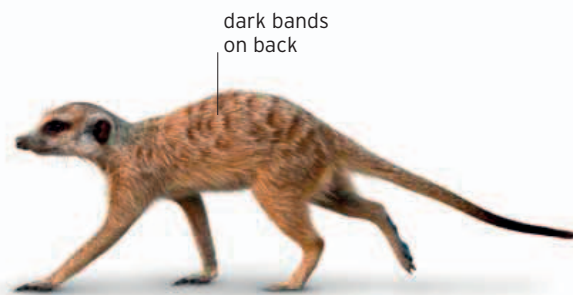


Meerkat

Suricata suricatta



Small enough to sit in the palm of a human hand, meerkats are feisty, highly territorial mongooses that live in complex groups, known as mobs, clans, or gangs, of up to 50 animals. Each clan consists of a dominant male and female, with subordinate “helpers” of both sexes. In smaller clans, the alpha female gives birth to most litters, while the male tries to prevent other males from mating. The female also releases pheromones that stop young females from coming into season. If this fails, she attacks ovulating or pregnant females, often killing their pups. During late pregnancy, she drives off other females to safeguard her young. They rejoin the clan later.

Mob mentality

Meerkat society relies on cooperation, and helpers play a crucial role in raising pups to adulthood. Some young females produce milk to help feed the dominant

female’s pups, while helpers of both sexes alert them to predators, teach them to forage, protect them, and bring them food during the weaning process.

Meerkats depend on their clan in many vital ways. A gang digs a series of multilevel tunnel-and-room burrows in its territory—usually with many entrances—where all its members sleep at night and rest during the hottest part of the day. In the morning, they emerge to warm up in the sun. They spend the day foraging and taking turns on lookout duty. While the clan searches for beetles, lizards, and scorpions, or digs for tubers and roots that supply much-needed water, sentry meerkats keep watch for predators such as jackals, snakes, and, especially, birds of prey. When alerted to danger by an alarm call, clan members retreat to a nearby bolthole or mob together to ward off the predator. If an adult is surprised, it may use its own body to shield nearby pups.

A meerkat clan may have as many as **1,000 boltholes** in its territory



△ GROUP ATTACK

A meerkat mob acts as a single unit to ward off predators. All members arch their backs, raise their tails, and growl and hiss to intimidate the enemy.

▷ OLD AND YOUNG

Meerkats are highly social and the father may take an active role in guarding their pups. Nonbreeding members of the clan also look after the young.

